

Use Claude to Prepare for Hard Conversations

The conversation isn't easier to avoid. It's just harder later.

"You already know what needs to be said. Claude helps you figure out how."

THE PROBLEM

Hard conversations don't get easier on their own.

There's a conversation you've been putting off. Maybe it's with your teenager about something you've noticed. Maybe it's with a co-parent, a teacher, a doctor, or a partner. You know it needs to happen. You keep waiting for the right moment.

The right moment doesn't come. What comes instead is more distance, more tension, or a problem that gets bigger because nobody addressed it early.

The reason we avoid hard conversations isn't lack of care. It's lack of preparation. We don't know how to start. We're afraid of saying the wrong thing and making it worse. We rehearse it in our heads and it always goes badly.

Claude won't have the conversation for you. That's not what this is. But Claude is remarkably good at helping you get clear before you walk into the room — figuring out what you actually want, finding an opening that isn't aggressive, and thinking through how the other person might respond.

Preparation doesn't guarantee a perfect conversation. But it changes everything about how you show up. And how you show up is often the difference between a conversation that connects and one that shuts down.

THE PROMPT

Your Template

Use this prompt before any difficult conversation. You don't need to have it figured out — two sentences about the situation is enough to get started.

PROMPT

I need to have a difficult conversation with [person or relationship – e.g. my teenager, my child's teacher, my partner].

The situation: [describe what happened or what you need to address – even 2 sentences is enough].

Please help me:

1. Figure out what I actually want from this conversation (the outcome)
2. Find an opening line that's honest but not aggressive
3. Anticipate how they might respond and how I could handle it
4. Identify one thing I should NOT say

SEE IT IN ACTION

A parent talks to their teenager about dropping grades.

Filled in: 'My teenager's grades have dropped significantly this semester and I don't know why. I'm worried but I don't want to be accusatory.' Claude returned this:

CLAUDE'S RESPONSE

What you actually want: Not to punish or lecture — to understand what's happening and whether they need support you don't know about yet.

Opening line: 'I noticed your grades have changed this semester and I wanted to check in — not to be on your case, but because I want to understand what's going on for you.'

If they get defensive: They might say 'I'm fine' or go quiet. Try: 'You don't have to have an answer right now. I just want you to know I'm not here to be angry with you.'

One thing NOT to say: 'You're not trying.' Even if it feels true, this closes the conversation before it starts. It puts them on defense before they've had a chance to explain.

YOUR TURN

Think of one conversation you've been putting off.

Not the biggest conversation of your life — just one you've been avoiding this week. Run it through the prompt. You'll spend five minutes with Claude before you spend an hour worrying. Here's how to get the most out of it:

- Be specific about the situation. The more real detail you give, the more useful Claude's response will be.
- After Claude gives you an opening line, say: 'Give me two other versions — one warmer, one more direct.' Pick the one that sounds like you.
- Ask Claude to role-play. Say: 'Respond the way my teenager might.' Practice your replies before the real conversation.
- Go in knowing what you want. Claude's first step — clarifying the outcome — is the most important part. Know your goal and you can stay grounded when it gets emotional.

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